

Don't Worry, Mom

Game Design Document

v0.1 — Unity 6.3 — Single Player — Narrative / Dialogue

1. Overview

Don't Worry, Mom is a short-session narrative game about the small, constant lies we tell the people who love us. The player is a young woman — smart, scrappy, and currently failing upward — who receives a phone call from her worried mother. Over the course of ten questions, the player must keep Mom calm without sounding so calm that Mom knows she's being lied to.

- **Genre:** Dialogue-driven narrative / social stealth puzzle.
- **Engine:** Unity 6.3 (URP, 2D).
- **Platform targets:** PC (Windows/Mac), with mobile portrait layout as a stretch goal.
- **Session length:** 5–8 minutes per run. High replayability through question pools and branching tone.
- **Perspective:** First-person audio fiction, presented as a stylized phone UI. No character animation required for MVP.
- **Tone:** Funny but grounded. Closer to Fleabag than to a sitcom. The humor comes from the gap between the player's chaotic life and the reassuring sentences she has to produce on demand.

2. Design Pillars

- **Every word is a choice.** There is no filler dialogue. Each line the player picks shifts Mom's state in a measurable way.
- **Lying is a resource.** Lies are often the right answer — but each one raises Suspicion. Truth is cheaper but hurts Mom. The tension is economic, not moral.
- **Mom is a character, not a puzzle.** Her reactions feel like a real person's: she remembers, she circles back, she notices the pause before you answered.
- **The life is the joke; the call is the game.** Backstory is absurd (a pyramid scheme, a raccoon in the bathroom, an ex who lives in the walls). The interaction is tender.

3. Core Gameplay Loop

A session is one phone call, consisting of 10 questions from Mom. The loop per question is:

1. **Mom asks.** A question appears as a chat-style bubble, typed out character-by-character with a typewriter sound. Example: "So, did you eat today? Real food?"
2. **Player chooses.** 3–4 response options appear. Each is tagged internally (not visibly) as TRUTH, LIE, or DEFLECT, with a tone modifier (CONFIDENT / VAGUE / OVERSHARE).
3. **Mom reacts.** Two meters shift: Worry and Suspicion. Mom delivers a short reply that reflects the shift — sometimes a follow-up, sometimes a guilt trip, sometimes relief.
4. **Repeat ×10.** Questions escalate. Later questions may reference earlier answers — if the player lied about eating and then mentions being at a restaurant, Suspicion spikes.
5. **Resolution.** The call ends with one of several endings based on final meter values.

4. Meters & Win Conditions

Two hidden meters track Mom's internal state. They are visualized as stylized bars on Mom's side of the phone UI — but without numbers, so the player reads them by feel.

Meter	Range	Start	Meaning
Worry	0–100	40	How anxious Mom is about her daughter's life. Raised by truths (especially messy ones), lowered by reassurance.
Suspicion	0–100	10	How much Mom suspects she's being managed. Raised by lies, contradictions, and over-rehearsed answers. Lowered by small, believable truths.

Win / Lose

- **WIN — Steady Daughter:** End with Worry < 50 AND Suspicion < 50.
- **LOSE — Mom is spiraling:** Worry hits 100 at any point, or ends ≥ 80.
- **LOSE — Caught:** Suspicion hits 100, or a contradiction is triggered (see §6).
- **SECRET ENDING — The Truth:** End with Worry < 30 AND Suspicion < 20 AND ≥ 7 TRUTH responses. Mom says the thing she never says.

5. Dialogue System

5.1 Data model

All content is authored in ScriptableObjects for designer-friendly editing in Unity, with JSON export for version control and potential localization.

Question

- id (string, unique)
- promptText (string) — Mom's line
- category (enum: HEALTH, WORK, MONEY, LOVE, HOME, FRIENDS, FUTURE)
- tier (int 1–3) — unlocks by question index (1: Q1–3, 2: Q4–7, 3: Q8–10)
- responses: List<Response>
- factTags: string[] — facts this question can establish or contradict (e.g., "ate_today", "has_job")

Response

- text (string) — what the player says
- type (enum: TRUTH, LIE, DEFLECT)
- tone (enum: CONFIDENT, VAGUE, OVERSHARE)
- worryDelta (int, typically -15..+20)
- suspicionDelta (int, typically -10..+25)
- factsSet: Dictionary<string, bool> — flags set if chosen (e.g., {ate_today: true})

- `momReplyId` — id of the follow-up micro-line Mom says in reaction

5.2 Tone modifiers

Tone modifies the base deltas to model how Mom reads the delivery:

Tone	Worry mod	Suspicion mod	Feel
CONFIDENT	×1.0	+5 on LIE	Sounds rehearsed. Great cover, but Mom knows her daughter doesn't talk like that.
VAGUE	×0.9	+3	Hedges. Lower stakes both directions. The safe default.
OVERSHARE	×1.3	-5	Too many details. Mom relaxes — unless the details are alarming.

6. Contradiction System

The fun of lying is that it gets harder to maintain. Each Response can set or contradict factTags. The ContradictionTracker watches these across the session.

- **Soft contradiction:** A new response tonally conflicts with an earlier established fact. +15 Suspicion, Mom says something like "Wait — I thought you said..."
- **Hard contradiction:** A new response directly negates an established fact (`ate_today: false` after `ate_today: true`). +30 Suspicion, Mom goes quiet for a beat, then follows up with a targeted question that bypasses the normal question queue.
- **Consistency bonus:** Holding a lie across 3+ related questions without contradiction grants -10 Suspicion (Mom's gut relaxes). This rewards committing to a bit.

7. Question Director

Instead of a fixed script, the director picks the next question based on state. This keeps runs fresh and makes Mom feel responsive.

- **Tiered pool:** Each tier has ~15 questions authored. Tier advances with question index.
- **Weighting:** Categories the player has lied in recently are weighted higher (Mom circles back to what felt off). Categories with high Worry contribution are weighted higher if Suspicion is low ("are you sure?" loops).
- **No repeats:** A question id never repeats within a session.
- **Scripted hooks:** Q1 is always a warm opener ("Hi sweetheart, is this a bad time?"). Q10 is always a closer ("Okay, I'll let you go — just tell me one real thing.") — the final answer is weighted 2× for ending calculation.

8. Sample Content

Example question — Tier 1, HEALTH

Mom: "Did you eat something today? A real meal, not coffee?"

Response	Type	Tone	ΔW / ΔS
"I had eggs. With toast. I'm fine, Mom."	LIE	CONFIDENT	-10 / +8
"...I had like half a granola bar?"	TRUTH	VAGUE	+15 / -5
"I'm literally eating right now. Chewing. Hear it?"	LIE	OVERSHARE	-8 / +15
"Can we not start with this?"	DEFLECT	VAGUE	+5 / +10

Example question — Tier 3, WORK

Mom: "Your cousin said she saw you at the mall on Tuesday. At 2pm."
(Only triggers if player earlier established has_job: true.)

Response	Type	Tone	ΔW / ΔS
"Client meeting. We walked and talked."	LIE	CONFIDENT	-5 / +20
"Okay. I got let go last month."	TRUTH	VAGUE	+25 / -20
"Tell Rachel to mind her business."	DEFLECT	CONFIDENT	+10 / +5

9. Narrative Direction

- **The Daughter (player):** Late 20s. Was supposed to be a lawyer. Currently sells essential oils on Instagram, lives with an ex who she told her mother she broke up with, owns a cat that she's pretty sure is just a very calm raccoon.
- **Mom:** Loves her daughter catastrophically. Has a sixth sense for when something is wrong. Also has the emotional leverage of someone who raised a child alone and will not let her forget it. Not a villain. Not a joke.
- **Writing rules:** Mom never swears. The daughter's internal options often do. No line over 18 words. Humor lives in specificity — "a raccoon" is funnier than "a pet."

10. UI / UX

- **Screen metaphor:** The entire game takes place inside a stylized phone UI, portrait-oriented, even on desktop (letterboxed).
- **Mom's side:** Chat bubbles on the left, with a photo/avatar and her name as the contact. Typing indicator when she's composing. A pulsing "call active" timer at the top.

- **Player's side:** Response options appear as draft bubbles at the bottom. Hover/focus previews the tone with a subtle color (blue = confident, grey = vague, orange = overshare) — but NOT the meter effect.
- **Meter visualization:** Two small icons next to Mom's avatar — a heart (Worry) and an eye (Suspicion). They pulse and color-shift when they change. No numbers.
- **Accessibility:** Full keyboard navigation (1–4 to pick options). Typewriter effect skippable. High-contrast mode. All audio has captions.

11. Audio

- **VO:** Mom's lines fully voice-acted (MVP: one actress, ~150 lines). Daughter is silent — player reads her own lines in their head, which protects the self-insert.
- **SFX:** Phone ambient hum, typewriter ticks for incoming text, soft "ding" for meter shifts (tuned to be felt, not heard), a single gut-punch sting for hard contradictions.
- **Music:** A single, slow lo-fi loop under the entire call. Tempo and filter shift subtly with Worry. Silence on the secret ending.

12. Technical Architecture (Unity 6.3)

- **Rendering:** 2D URP. Everything is UI Toolkit / uGUI — no scene geometry.
- **Content authoring:** ScriptableObjects for Question, Response, MomReply. Editor tooling to validate factTag consistency across the corpus.
- **Core systems (MonoBehaviours / plain C# services):** undefined
 - **GameSession** — owns meters, turn index, fact dictionary, RNG seed
 - **QuestionDirector** — selects next question from pool given state
 - **DialoguePresenter** — drives typewriter, bubble spawn, audio cues
 - **ContradictionTracker** — observes factsSet, emits soft/hard contradiction events
 - **MomController** — picks reply line given event + meter state
 - **EndingResolver** — evaluates final state, routes to ending scene
- **Save data:** Per-run seed + chosen response ids, stored locally for a "share your call" recap screen. No cloud save for MVP.
- **Claude Code workflow note:** Keep ScriptableObject assets out of Claude Code's editing path — let it generate the C# systems and author dialogue content as JSON that a small Editor importer converts to SOs. This avoids .meta / GUID churn.

13. Scope & Milestones

Milestone	Target	Deliverable
M1 — Vertical slice	Week 2	One full 10-question call, placeholder VO, both meters, 1 ending. Playable start-to-finish.
M2 — Content pass	Week 5	45 questions across 3 tiers, contradiction system live, 4 endings, secret ending gated.
M3 — Feel	Week 7	Final VO, audio mix, typewriter/tone juice, accessibility

pass		pass.
M4 — Ship	Week 9	itch.io release, Steam page up, gameplay trailer.

14. Risks & Open Questions

- **Tonal risk:** Mom must not read as a punchline or a villain. Mitigation: table-read all lines aloud, cut anything that gets a laugh at Mom's expense rather than at the situation.
- **Replay risk:** 10 questions is short. If the content pool is too small, run 2 feels identical to run 1. Mitigation: ≥45 questions authored, director weighting, multiple endings.
- **Difficulty legibility:** Players may not intuit that Suspicion and Worry are opposing forces. Mitigation: Q1 is a tutorial in disguise — it deliberately offers one obviously reassuring lie and one obviously worrying truth, and Mom's reaction teaches the meter visually.
- **Open:** Does the player ever hear their own voice (e.g., on the secret ending)? Leaning no — but worth prototyping once.